

Moolah Points — Gen Z / Young Adult Customer Personas & Capture Strategy

Prepared: July 21, 2026 **Scope:** Consumer-facing personas for shoppers enrolling in a Moolah Points loyalty program at a liquor store, smoke/vape shop, or convenience store — not the store-owner buyer persona (covered separately in `moolahpoints-market-research-2026-07.md`).

0. Read this first — a legal/compliance correction to the brief

The request was to target "Gen Z and younger crowd who are over 18." For two of Moolah Points' three core verticals, **18 is not the legal or platform-compliant threshold — 21 is.**

Category	Federal minimum age	Source
Alcohol	21 — National Minimum Drinking Age Act (1984), enforced in all 50 states	Standard federal law
Tobacco & vapor products	21 — federal "Tobacco 21" law, signed December 2019	FDA retail tobacco enforcement
General convenience-store merchandise (snacks, drinks, most non-restricted goods)	No age restriction	N/A

This isn't just a legal line — it's an active platform-enforcement line. As of 2026, **Meta requires all US alcohol ads to be targeted 21+ (25+ for any featured influencer), with age-gating enforced on every linked landing page, lead form, and Messenger flow. TikTok goes further and doesn't allow retail/e-commerce ads promoting alcohol sale at all**, and requires a visible "21+" badge in the first frame of any alcohol-adjacent video content it does permit. [Sources: [HawtAds](#), [Meta Alcohol Advertising Policy 2026](#), [AuditSocials](#), [TikTok Alcohol & Gambling Ads 2026](#)]

What this means practically: the personas below split into two groups. The liquor and smoke/vape personas target **legal-age young adults, roughly 21-27** — the legal-purchasing end of Gen Z (Gen Z spans birth years ~1997-2012, so in 2026 the legal-age slice is ~21-29; we focus tighter on 21-27 since that's where the behavioral data below is richest). The convenience-store persona is the one place an 18-20 audience is genuinely fair game, because it covers general merchandise, not age-restricted product.

This document proceeds on that corrected basis. Every recommendation below assumes strict 21+ gating on any alcohol- or tobacco/vape-adjacent content, consistent with the PACT Act/SHAFT/TCPA guidance already published in [Blog #2](#).

1. Personas

Persona A — "The Discovery Drinker" (Liquor vertical, ages 21-27)

Who they are: Just aged into legal drinking within the last few years, or in their mid-20s and increasingly deliberate about it. Drinks less often than prior generations did at the same age, but treats each drinking occasion as more intentional — small-format cocktails, a "daycap" instead of a big night out, trying something new rather than defaulting to the usual.

What the data says about them: - Not drinking less so much as **drinking differently** — favoring low-ABV spritzers, dessert-inspired cocktails, and smaller pours over volume. [Ask Attest, Gen Z Alcohol Trends 2026] - Awareness and interest in sub-3% ABV beer/cider is up year over year (49% awareness, 47% interest, both climbing); low-ABV cocktails now have 63% awareness and 51% interest. [Ask Attest] - **54.5%** "often" or "sometimes" choose non-alcoholic or low-alcohol alternatives; another 22% are curious but haven't tried yet. Only a minority are fully outside this trend. [Ask Attest] - **43% say they're more likely to try a new drink product if it's marketed around the sober-curious lifestyle** — moderation-friendly framing is a positive purchase driver, not a niche concern. [Ask Attest] - A third believe alcohol is "generally unhealthy," and many are fluent in the concept of "hangxiety" — this generation grew up with public-health messaging prior generations didn't. [Ask Attest]

What they want from a loyalty program: Not a bigger discount for buying more — that's the wrong lever entirely for a generation moderating volume. They respond to **discovery** (new products, limited releases, a reason to try something), **gamified engagement** (challenges, instant digital rewards, leaderboards — 46% of Gen Z engage more with gamified programs than flat-discount ones), and **early access** over pure price-off. [Advantage Club, Antavo Gen Z Loyalty 2026]

Where they are: Instagram has the highest reach (89% use it, highest time allocation), TikTok drives the most product discovery (77% use TikTok specifically to find products), and Discord/BeReal are where the more private, high-trust engagement happens. [Sprout Social, Hootsuite Gen Z Statistics 2026]

Persona B — "The Switch-Curious Regular" (Smoke/vape vertical, ages 21-27)

Who they are: A regular at a smoke or vape shop, but the relationship with the product category is more complicated than "loyal nicotine consumer." Young adults 18-29 have the highest vaping prevalence of any age group, but this same cohort is also the most quit-motivated.

What the data says about them: - Adults 18-29 report the highest vaping prevalence of any age bracket (18%, vs. 6% who smoke cigarettes) — vaping, not cigarettes, is this cohort's dominant nicotine product. [SingleCare, Vaping Statistics 2026] - **67% of young adult nicotine users aged 18-24 say they plan to quit.** [Truth Initiative, 2026] This is the single most important fact for how Moolah/retailer content should be framed in this vertical — a majority of the customer base is actively trying to reduce or exit the category, not looking to be marketed deeper into it. - A notable emerging counter-trend: some doctors report **cigarettes regaining social appeal with people in their 20s** even as vaping remains the bigger category overall — a reminder that behavior here is shifting fast and shouldn't be assumed static. [UVA Health / WWBT, July 2026] - Product variety (flavor, device type, nicotine strength options) and non-nicotine adjacent categories (glass, CBD, accessories) are real parts of smoke-shop basket composition, not just repeat nicotine purchases.

What this means for loyalty design: This is the one persona where the "more purchases, more rewards" default loyalty logic is in real tension with both the customer's own stated goals and brand-safety/regulatory optics (FTC and state attorneys general actively scrutinize marketing that could be read as encouraging youth or first-time nicotine use). The safer, more defensible, and arguably more loyalty-building design is to **reward variety, accessories, and category-adjacent purchases** (device upgrades, glass, CBD/non-nicotine product lines) rather than pure consumption-volume incentives, and to keep messaging squarely on the store relationship (selection, expertise, service) rather than product-consumption prompts. This isn't just risk-avoidance — it's also more consistent with the compliance-authority positioning already built into Blog #2 and the content strategy's Pillar 1.

Where they are: Same platform mix as Persona A (Instagram reach, TikTok discovery), but with a strong SHAFT-filtering constraint on any SMS content mentioning tobacco/vape products directly (see the compliance guide) — campaigns need to route through a landing page rather than naming products in the text itself.

Persona C — "The C-Store Discovery Regular" (Convenience vertical, ages 18-24 — the one persona where 18+ genuinely applies)

Who they are: The convenience store isn't a fallback stop for this group — it's a destination in its own right. This is the persona with the most upside and the least regulatory friction, since it covers general merchandise, not age-restricted product.

What the data says about them: - **3 in 4 Gen Z adults visit a convenience store at least once a week**, and **92% say they enjoy browsing** — this cohort treats the c-store as a browsing destination, not just a quick transaction. [Convenience Store News / NACS, 2026] - **9 in 10 say they browse on purpose**, usually looking for a small indulgence or something new to try — discovery-seeking behavior, not routine restocking. [NACS] - They shop by **mood, need, and occasion** rather than traditional category (snacks/meals/beverages) — "energy" is the fastest-climbing demand signal, growing at nearly 2x the prior year's rate. [Tastewise via NACS] - **1.5x more visually driven** than older shoppers when trying a new snack — packaging and shelf presentation matter disproportionately to this group. [NACS, Sweets & Snacks 2026] - Functional sodas, protein-forward snacks, and "better-for-you" positioning are all climbing, alongside continued strength in indulgent/nostalgic treats — this cohort wants comfort, energy, and novelty simultaneously, not one at the expense of the others. [NACS]

What they want from a loyalty program: Because there's no age-restriction friction here, this is the persona to be most aggressive and playful with — gamified discovery mechanics (a "try something new" bonus-points trigger fits naturally with the 92%-enjoy-browsing data point), visually-driven social content, and the lowest-friction possible enrollment (phone number only, instant first reward) to capture a shopper who's already treating the store as a destination.

Where they are: Heaviest TikTok/Instagram Reels overlap of all three personas, plus the strongest fit for UGC-style content (snack-haul videos, "what's new at my corner store" browsing content) since this is organic, native behavior for this age group already, not something that needs to be manufactured.

2. The "perfect way to capture" this audience — strategy

2a. Structural principle: let the compliance line do the segmentation for you

Don't build one "Gen Z campaign" spanning all three verticals. Build the **c-store persona as the wide-open acquisition engine** (18+, no restrictions, highest natural enthusiasm per the browsing/discovery data above), and treat liquor/smoke-shop content as **21+-gated retention and upsell** for the same customer once they age in or are already of legal age. A shopper who enrolls in Moolah Points at 19 buying energy drinks and snacks is a warm, already-enrolled contact by the time they turn 21 — that's a genuinely valuable lifecycle advantage a competitor starting cold at 21 doesn't have, and it's fully compliant because the initial enrollment touchpoint never involved an age-restricted product.

2b. Loyalty mechanics: gamification over discounts, discovery over volume

The data is consistent across all three personas: flat discounts and "buy more, save more" mechanics are the weakest lever for this cohort. What works instead: - **Gamified challenges and instant digital rewards** — QR scavenger hunts, streak bonuses, leaderboards. 46% of Gen Z respond more to gamified programs than flat-discount ones. [Advantage Club] - **Early access over price-off** — first access to a new SKU, a limited flavor drop, or a new product category outperforms a percentage discount for this cohort's stated preferences. [Antavo] - **"Try something new" triggers** — directly maps to the 92%-enjoy-browsing / 9-in-10-browse-on-purpose data for the c-store persona, and to the 43%-more-likely-to-try-if-sober-curious-framed data for the liquor persona. - **Equity, not just top-spender rewards** — Gen Z loyalty research flags that programs rewarding only high spenders alienate this cohort; occasional/exploratory customers should still feel recognized. [Advantage Club] - **Mobile-first, app-optional** — 43.5% prefer logging in via a mobile app specifically (higher than other generations), which is worth noting against Moolah's own no-app, phone-number-first architecture: for this specific audience, a lightweight web-based "my rewards" view accessible from the SMS link should feel app-like (fast, visual, mobile-native) even without requiring a download, since the underlying preference is for a good mobile experience, not necessarily an installed app.

2c. Content and channel strategy

- **TikTok and Instagram Reels are the discovery layer** — 77% of Gen Z use TikTok specifically to find products, and short-form video is where this cohort expects to encounter a store or brand before they ever walk in. Raw, unedited, "behind the counter" style content (already the recommended format in the RetailzPOS/Moolah social strategy) outperforms polished ads with this audience specifically.
- **Discord and BeReal are relationship-deepening, not acquisition, channels** — not a priority for initial capture, but worth monitoring as a place engaged, already-enrolled customers might organically discuss a store or product (e.g., a local Discord server for a college town's late-night c-store runs).
- **UGC is the highest-leverage content type for the c-store persona specifically** — "what's new at my corner store" browsing/haul-style content is already native behavior for this age group; the loyalty program should give them an explicit reason to film it (a bonus-points trigger for a photo/video share, for example) rather than trying to manufacture the content in-house.
- **For liquor content**, lean into the moderation-aligned framing directly — a "try the new low-ABV option, earn double points" campaign is both on-trend (43% purchase-intent lift from sober-curious framing) and inherently more defensible from a responsible-marketing standpoint than volume-based promotion.

- **For smoke/vape content**, keep messaging on store relationship, selection, and category-adjacent products (accessories, CBD/non-nicotine lines) rather than consumption prompts, given the 67%-want-to-quit data point — this is both the safer regulatory posture and, done well, a genuine point of differentiation ("the shop that treats you like a person, not a customer to upsell").

2d. Compliance guardrails (non-negotiable, ties directly to Blog #2)

- **21+ age-gating on every touchpoint** tied to alcohol or tobacco/vape content: ad targeting, landing pages, SMS opt-in flows, and any influencer partnership (25+ for the influencer themselves, per Meta's policy).
- **No paid retail/e-commerce alcohol-sale ads on TikTok** — the platform doesn't allow them. Organic, brand-level content (store culture, staff picks, general education) is the available lane there for the liquor vertical; paid acquisition for liquor should run on Meta/Google with correct 21+ targeting instead.
- **SHAFT-aware SMS copy** for any campaign touching the liquor or smoke/vape personas — route to a landing page rather than naming alcohol/tobacco products directly in the text body, consistent with the compliant-campaign example in Blog #2.
- **No youth-coded creative** in smoke/vape marketing specifically (cartoon-style branding, imagery that could read as appealing to a below-21 audience) — this is both a state-law flashpoint in a growing number of jurisdictions and a reputational risk independent of what's strictly legal.

2e. Where this plugs into the existing content strategy

This isn't a replacement for the 5-pillar content strategy already built (`moolahpoints-content-strategy-2026-07.md`) — it's an audience layer on top of it. Concretely: - Pillar 3 ("The First Four Visits" / vertical proof) gets a Gen Z-specific angle: the c-store persona's high weekly-visit rate (3 in 4 visit weekly) makes the 4-visit-to-95%-return-rate stat land even faster for this audience than for the general population. - Pillar 4 ("Text Beats App") should be nuanced for this audience specifically — the SMS-first case is still right (91-98% open rates don't change by generation), but the *destination* the text links to should feel mobile-app-quality, matching this cohort's specific preference for app-like experiences even without requiring an actual install. - The Topic 5 social content set (c-store breakfast/beverage trend, already in the calendar) is a natural home for Persona C content — extend it with a "what's new, try it and earn double points" discovery angle.

3. Summary table

Persona	Vertical	Age	Age-restricted content allowed?	Primary lever	Primary channel
The Discovery Drinker	Liquor	21-27	Yes, with 21+ gating everywhere	Moderation-aligned discovery, gamified early access	Instagram (reach), TikTok (discovery, organic only)
The Switch-Curious Regular	Smoke/vape	21-27	Yes, with 21+ gating + extra caution given 67% want to quit	Variety/accessories over consumption volume; store-relationship framing	Instagram, TikTok (organic only), SHAFT-safe SMS
	Convenience	18-24	N/A — general merchandise only	Gamified "try something new," UGC, visual discovery	TikTok, Instagram Reels, UGC

Persona	Vertical	Age	Age-restricted content allowed?	Primary lever	Primary channel
The C-Store Discovery Regular					

Sources: [Ask Attest — Gen Z Alcohol Trends 2026](#), [SingleCare — Vaping Statistics 2026](#), [Truth Initiative — Young Adult Nicotine Quit Intentions 2026](#), [UVA Health/WWBT — Cigarettes Regaining Appeal](#), [Advantage Club — Gen Z Loyalty Program Preferences](#), [Antavo — Gen Z and the Future of Loyalty 2026](#), [Sprout Social — Gen Z Social Media Statistics](#), [Hootsuite — 26 Gen Z Statistics for 2026](#), [Convenience Store News — Gen Z Discovery Destinations](#), [NACS — Sweets & Snacks 2026: Targeting Gen Z](#), [HawtAds — Meta Alcohol Advertising Policy 2026](#), [AuditSocials — TikTok Alcohol & Gambling Ads 2026](#)